

SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: HARDING UNIVERSITY

TRADITIONAL

On-Site Review: Date not reported

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	WHAT THE RATING MEANS
4 — EXCEEDS	Coursework and training CONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
3 — MEETS	Coursework and training USUALLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
2 — APPROACHING	Coursework and training INCONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
1 — BELOW	Coursework and training RARELY OR DO NOT address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.

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REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS		
REVIEW AREA 1 LITERACY COURSEWORK	REVIEW AREA 2 FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES	REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT
EXCEEDS	MEETS	MEETS
CRITERIA REVIEWED		
9	11	7

PROGRAM INFORMATION

INSTITUTION NAME	Harding University
LOCATION	Searcy, Arkansas
PROGRAM REVIEWED	Undergraduate program, traditional face to face route and nontraditional online degree completion route to licensure; four literacy courses reviewed
PATHWAY	Traditional
REVIEW FRAMEWORK	TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024)
REVIEWING BODY	Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)
SITE VISIT DATES	Not reported

REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY COURSEWORK

REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
EXCEEDS 9 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Overview of the science of reading	Exceeds
Concepts of print instruction	Exceeds
Collaborative communication, oral language instruction	Exceeds
Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction	Exceeds
Phonics, orthography, automatic word recognition instruction	Exceeds
Fluency instruction	Exceeds
Vocabulary instruction	Exceeds
Text comprehension instruction	Exceeds
Writing instruction	Approaching
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers examined four literacy courses in the undergraduate program, RDNG 3120 Foundations of Reading, RDNG 4130 Teaching Language Comprehension, SPED 4160 Literacy Assessment and Intervention, and ELED 3170 Teaching Young Writers, drawing on course syllabi, course observations and instructor interviews. Eight of the nine criteria exceeded expectations. Reviewers found the science of reading spiraled across coursework and aligned to Residency I, with response to intervention and multitiered system of supports taught in authentic classroom settings and HQIM such as UFLI, DIBELS, PAST and decodable texts used in modeling, quizzes and analysis tasks. Candidates administered research-based screeners, analyzed the results to plan instruction, and submitted video of their intervention teaching for instructor feedback. Concepts of print, oral language, phonological and phonemic awareness, phonics, fluency, vocabulary and text comprehension instruction each combined explicit modeling with field application. Writing instruction was approaching, because ELED 3170 gave candidates one opportunity to plan a writing lesson within science and social studies and did not fully cover evidence-based practices for differentiating writing instruction.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Prioritize explicit, evidence-based writing coursework that systematically integrates every component of the writing process and ensures candidates can both understand and apply key principles across all content areas • Make instruction on differentiated instruction for diverse learners appropriate and clear, so that candidates can support students with varying linguistic backgrounds and developmental stages during literacy instruction • Expand candidate access to a wider range of HQIM, and build on print awareness coursework by exploring the developmental process of letter formation and its relationship to transcription fluency	

REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 11 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Selection of clinical placement schools	Exceeds
Selection of cooperating teachers (mentor teachers)	Exceeds
Opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice	Exceeds
Field-based placements provide opportunities to use HQIM	Exceeds
Responsibilities build to candidate readiness for full responsibility	Exceeds
Opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children	Exceeds
Opportunities to apply learning about students who experience difficulty reading	Exceeds
Mentor teachers are skillful and can coach candidates	Exceeds
Faculty and supervisors guide and evaluate candidates through training	Approaching
Quality of written and oral feedback	Approaching
Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning	Meets
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers examined field placements in the Searcy School District, where all interns are placed, and interviewed faculty, partnership districts and mentor teachers; all observations for this review were prerecorded. Eight of the eleven criteria exceeded expectations. Placement schools were selected with district partners by the field experience team, and each candidate was paired with a mentor who had completed the science of reading proficiency pathway and HQIM training, verified on a principal-signed form. Two residencies formed a yearlong internship beginning on the first day teachers report, with early access to the adopted curriculum, point of practice cycles and formal evaluations by university site coordinators and mentor teachers. During Residency I candidates spent three days a week in placements while taking RDNG 4130 and SPED 4160 and delivered Tier 1 and Tier 2 interventions. Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning met expectations. Training for faculty, supervisors and supervising practitioners and the quality of written and oral feedback were approaching, with feedback accurate and skill focused but inconsistent in depth, next steps and reference to student learning.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Train all literacy faculty and supervising practitioners to give high-quality post-observation oral and written feedback that addresses impact on student learning, connects to previous feedback and provides actionable next steps with strategies and modeling • Schedule regular calibration meetings where faculty and supervisors analyze candidate performance data from point of practice cycles and the science of reading rubric, including intentional written feedback in the areas identified • Make oral and written feedback an integral part of the monitoring system and review it to determine the impact of the revised training on how candidates receive feedback and on the strength of coursework and training	

REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 7 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Quality of data the program collects and uses	Meets
Internal quality control gates (or checkpoints) and intervention plans	Meets
Quality of monitoring	Approaching
Monitoring coursework quality, teaching quality, and clinical connections	Meets
Quality improvement planning	Meets
Partnerships improve candidate experiences with HQIM	Exceeds
Evaluation of partnerships for readiness to teach early literacy	Exceeds
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers examined the data the program collects, its quality control gates, its monitoring practices and its improvement planning, and interviewed faculty, program leaders and district leadership. Four criteria met expectations, two exceeded and one was approaching. The program compared candidate self-scores with residency site coordinator ratings on four Danielson components, surveyed candidates on HQIM use, scored videoed teaching performances, compared final exam scores across faculty teaching the same course, analyzed point of practice cycle three data and reviewed foundations of reading pass rates, and those reviews produced new rubrics, earlier assignments and revised field expectations. Defined checkpoints and a handbook intervention process governed candidate progression, and all clinical supervisors taught courses and served as site coordinators, which kept coursework and field practice connected. The partnering district supplied curriculum copies and HQIM training before residency, and the program evaluated its partnerships each year with district leadership. Monitoring of field experience quality and of the observation and feedback system was inconsistent, and training had not extended to oral and written feedback.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Create a process for more rigorously collecting and monitoring feedback on literacy lessons, including oral debriefs and written comments, and use it to track patterns in candidate performance and determine each candidate's readiness to teach literacy • Establish a structured system of regular, high-quality training for all supervisors who give feedback, including inter-rater reliability exercises on interpreting performance data, with particular emphasis on point of practice cycle three observations • Integrate the results of ongoing feedback monitoring into the quality control gates that determine candidate progression, so that candidates who need targeted support are flagged early and receive individualized intervention • Prioritize observation and feedback data in improvement planning and embed it, with the outcomes of monitoring activities, into the department's strategic plan for continuous improvement	

Sources: TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review, Harding University, site visit dates not reported in the review report, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024). Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.